

Teaching Statement

Qilin Zhang

I teach economics by starting with the decision or problem that gives the model meaning. Students should understand what an economic idea is trying to explain before they are asked to manipulate equations, interpret a regression, or solve a model. In an introductory course, this means showing students how the methods in the textbook help them think about choices they make in their own lives, rather than asking them to memorize definitions and formulas. I use practice, feedback, and collaboration to help students move from economic intuition to formal analysis and then back to interpretation.

Teaching experience

At the University of Florida, I have served as Instructor of Record for ECP 3703 Managerial Economics since Spring 2026. This is an introductory undergraduate course, and I have direct responsibility for planning the course, presenting the material, designing assessments, and helping students apply basic economic reasoning to business and everyday decisions. My teaching experience also includes serving as a teaching assistant in undergraduate, MBA, master's, and Ph.D. courses, including Managerial Economics, Economic Data Analysis, Intermediate Macroeconomics, International Macroeconomics, Applied Game Theory, Macroeconomic Analysis, Macroeconomic Theory, and Computational Economics. In most of these assignments, I worked within the course structure and assessment plan set by the faculty instructor. The main exception was ECO 7206 Macroeconomic Theory, where I prepared and led a weekly discussion section for a more junior Ph.D. cohort. I reviewed the lecture material, prepared additional explanations, and worked through models and problem sets with students. Many of these exercises could be solved with paper and pencil. My goal was to make the logic of each model clear and to help students see how the assumptions led to the conclusions.

Student evaluations from my first semester as Instructor of Record provide encouraging evidence on several aspects of my teaching. With a response rate of 83.9 percent, students rated my enthusiasm for the course at 4.54 out of 5, my standards for communication and availability at 4.65, my ability to foster a positive learning environment at 4.19, and the promptness and usefulness of my feedback at 4.12. Students also described the chapter worksheets, in-class problems, and practice exams as useful preparation for the course exams. Several noted that the practice problems were closely related to the exam material and that the worksheets helped them study and catch up after missing class. This was my first semester as an instructor of record. In the following fall semester, I observed more consistent student participation as I continued to use structured practice, group homework, and opportunities for students to explain solutions. These evaluations and observations also point to a clear area for continued improvement: slowing down and making each step in a solution more explicit.

Economic intuition in introductory economics

I begin a new topic with a concrete decision, a graph, or a short numerical example. In Managerial Economics, for example, students can first reason through how a firm would respond to a change in price, cost, or demand before introducing the formal optimization problem. Once students can describe the decision in words, the algebra becomes a way to organize that reasoning rather than a set of procedures to memorize. This approach helps students connect an introductory economics course to decisions they encounter as consumers, workers, and managers.

My role in ECO 7206 Macroeconomic Theory was different. As a teaching assistant in a Ph.D. course, I mainly led students through the solution of formal models and problem sets in the weekly discussion section. I wrote out the steps, explained why each step followed, and paused when a common mistake was likely. I drew

on the mistakes I had made when learning the course myself to anticipate where students might lose track of an assumption, a step in a derivation, or the interpretation of a result. Because students often need time to work through difficult models, I tried to be a helpful and approachable TA who made it comfortable to ask questions and return to a problem more than once. The aim was not to replace the faculty instructor's lectures, but to give students a patient setting in which to practice solving the models themselves.

I also use group homework to make economic reasoning a shared activity. Students work through problems together, compare their approaches, and explain why an answer makes economic sense. The purpose is not only to divide up the questions. Students should learn how to communicate an argument, respond to a different approach, and take responsibility for a common solution. Those skills matter whether they continue in academia or work in industry.

Practice and feedback

Students learn economics by doing economics. I build short practice opportunities into class meetings and assignments rather than relying only on high-stakes exams. A typical activity might ask students to interpret a change in a graph, solve a small problem, explain a result in one paragraph, or revise an answer after seeing a common mistake. I use these exercises to see where the class is struggling and to adjust the pace or explanation before a misunderstanding becomes cumulative.

Feedback should tell students what to do next. On quantitative work, I distinguish an error in economic reasoning from an error in calculation or implementation. I also ask students to interpret their answer in words. This practice helps them see that a technically correct calculation can still be economically incomplete. When possible, I provide worked examples that show not only the final answer but also the decisions that lead to it, including how to check whether the answer is sensible.

Making economic reasoning accessible

I do not treat accessibility and rigor as competing goals. Students can learn demanding material when the steps are visible and the purpose of each step is clear. I introduce notation gradually, explain the role of assumptions, and return to the economic question after presenting a formal result. In an introductory course, I want students to leave with methods they can apply to everyday decisions, not a list of formulas they can reproduce only on an exam. In a theory course, I want them to understand how a model works well enough to solve it, explain it, and recognize how its conclusions change when its assumptions change.

I also try to create a classroom in which questions are part of the work rather than evidence that a student does not belong. When we review a practice exam, I invite students to come to the board and explain a problem. This gives them a chance to practice presenting an argument, and it gives the class several ways to understand the same solution. I invite students to compare approaches, identify a point of confusion, and explain a solution to a classmate. At the same time, I set clear expectations for preparation and participation. Students should leave a class knowing both what they can do and what they still need to practice.

Courses I can teach

I am prepared to teach Managerial Economics, Principles of Microeconomics, Principles of Macroeconomics, Intermediate Microeconomics, Intermediate Macroeconomics, Econometrics, Economic Data Analysis, and graduate or advanced undergraduate courses in microeconomic and macroeconomic theory. I would also be glad to contribute to courses in public economics, family economics, applied macroeconomics, and insurance. One course I would be particularly interested in developing is "Insuring Against Life-Stage Risks," which would connect insurance decisions to household behavior, public policy, and the risks people face over the life cycle.

My aim is for students to see economics as a way to ask precise questions about choices and institutions, not simply as a collection of formulas. When students can explain the intuition, carry out the analysis, and interpret the result, they have learned something they can use in a new setting. That is the standard I bring to my teaching.